

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1994-03-11

To an individual b ahá'í

dear b ahá'í friend, your letter of 31 december 1993 was received and referred to us for a response.

you quote the reference in paragraph 42 of the kitáb-i-Aqdas and ask how this can be understood as an anticipation of the institution of the guardianship.

As you correctly state, this passage relates entirely to the disposition of endowments dedicated to charity. in it bahá'u'lláh provides that the authority in this matter passes, after him, to the Agh'án. The Agh'án comprise not only the sons of bahá'u'lláh, but all his male descendants. Thus in his will and Testament 'Abdu'l-b ahá refers to Shoghi effendi as "the chosen branch," and provides that if the eldest son of the guardian did not possess the qualities which would befit him to be appointed as his successor, the guardian should "choose another branch [ghu'n] to succeed him."¹⁷⁷⁻¹ There is also a letter in which Shoghi effendi refers to his brother, ḡusayn, as a "ghu'n."

it should be noted that, although only two of the Agh'án are explicitly mentioned in the kitáb-i-'Ahd (the ghu'n-i-A'm and the ghu'n-i-Akbar, 176-9. eSw, p. 145.

¹⁷⁷⁻¹. w T, pp. 11, 12. ^{177 .1} ^{177 .2} ^{177 .3} ^{177 .4} m eS Sa g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e 7namely 'Abdu'l-b ahá and mírzá muḡammad-'Alí), paragraph 42 of the Aq- das refers to more than two. Arabic nouns have three forms for number:

Singular b ranch ghu'n dual two b ranches ghu'nán plural more than two b ranches Agh'án The Aqdas foresees a hereditary function for the Agh'án in relation to the disposition of endowments dedicated to charity. paragraph 42 of the Aqdas continues by stating that "after them" [i.e. the Agh'án] this authority passes "to the house of justice—should it be established in the world by then."

This envisages the possibility that the line of Agh'án would come to an end

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]